

Back in the Game

The internal strife within the Congress may bring benefits for the TDP that senses an opportunity to make a comeback

The TDP has a reason to be hopeful, or so it believes. At its annual *mahanadu* (state party convention), the first after the death of the Congress strongman YSR Reddy, the party seemed optimistic about taking on the rival Congress ever since its electoral debacle of 2004. The TDP has never been out of office for more than five years since its inception in 1982, but appeared to be floundering after the humiliating defeat in the 2009 elections. The exit of Reddy from the political stage and the internal strife in Congress has given a reason to N. Chandrababu Naidu to be hopeful about the party's future in the state.

Signalling the change in mood and plans for a new strategy, Nandamuri Balakrishna, a successful actor and son of the party founder N.T. Rama Rao, has cautioned TDP activists about the need to be prepared for a mid-term election. Pepping up the TDP cadre, NTR Junior, the actor grandson of the founder, emphasised on the need to rope in more women and youth to build a vibrant party cadre. The fact that they turned up on the concluding day of the three-day *mahanadu* to make these assertions suggests that the majority of the NTR family is with the TDP while his second daughter D. Purandeswari, minister of state for human resources, and son-in-law D. Venkateswara Rao, an MLA, are with the Congress.

The TDP chief is focusing on a strategy to wrest power. "Be prepared for any eventuality and don't think that the internal bickering in the Congress would ensure smooth sailing for the TDP," he told the partymen. Interestingly, the *mahanadu* did not debate the Telangana issue. On the contrary, the party's deputy leader in the Assembly, Nagam Janardhan Reddy, was prevented from raising the issue.

Naidu is trying hard to keep TDP activists engaged in a war of attrition with the Congress and allow little room for any other parties to emerge as frontrunner whether or not the state is divided in the near future. But he faces a major hurdle with Chiranjeevi and his PRP that has weaned away a section of the OBCs from the TDP, though some leaders have returned, and joined hands with the Congress in an electoral alliance. It can be a formidable one if it is a cohesive alliance.

With the Congress planning to test the political waters post-YSR, Naidu's meticulous planning to capture power again from the grassroots may pay rich dividends to the TDP.

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NAIDU IS WORKING ON A STRATEGY TO WREST POWER

age, I can't climb a wall, jump or run like Jagan," he says, adding, "I treated him like my son. After I took charge, I told him that this government is yours and whatever help you need will be given by me. But he chooses to conduct himself differently."

Many in the party are also worried about the fact that Reddy is using his media company that runs the *Sakshi Telugu* daily and a TV channel for an onslaught on Rosaiah's governance, accusing it of not only scuttling the pro-poor measures initiated by his father but even being a non-performing ministry. All this is music to the ears of N. Chandrababu Naidu who feels the prospects for Telugu Desam Party's (TDP) return have brightened after YSR's death (see box).

While Reddy is aware that his defiance cannot cross the tolerance threshold, the Congress too realises that it hardly has any young leaders who have the resources and the stamina to rally support across the state. Hence, it is putting up with Reddy's irreverence so that it may, if tactically advantageous, induct him as the APCC president ahead of the 2014 elections.

Ambition notwithstanding, Reddy realises that it is a daunting task to break away from the Congress. "I have nothing to do with Rosaiah. It is my faith and affection for Madam (Sonia Gandhi) that is important. But the way Rosaiah handled the situation in Mahbubabad is not acceptable," says Reddy, suggesting that there is no question of leaving the party. The Congress, on the other hand, is leaving little to chance. It has roped in Chiranjeevi and the PRP to make doubly sure that it wins four of the six seats in the biennial election to the Rajya Sabha in June.

At a time when it wants to strengthen its base, the party can do without the Reddy campaign. If his instincts serve him right, his future in the party may be assured. Else he may just be another fringe player. ■